

Rahul Singhi: 'Sports and education are not 180 degrees apart; they are one'



(L-R) Hogne Hide, Co-owner of Norway Chess; Rajeev Khanna, Vice President of Rajasthan Royals; Rahul Singhi, Director of Poornima University; Vivek Lodha, Co-founder and Director of the Premier Handball League; and moderator Prashant S., Partner at KPMG. R. V. MOORTHY

Rahul Singhi, Director of Poornima University, shared his deep commitment to sports during the *Sportstar Sports Conclave - Focus Rajasthan*. Reflecting on the university's foundation, he credited his mother for inspiring the emphasis on sports, saying, "When we started Poornima University, my mother was a major inspiration. She always encouraged us to stay fit and play sports." Singhi highlighted how sport has helped channel youthful energy, particularly in addressing aggression and negative behaviour, adding, "Sports became the perfect solution to channel that energy."

Singhi also shared significant developments at Poornima, revealing the university's investment of approximately Rs 2-2.5 crore in sports infrastructure. He further announced plans to offer new courses in sports management and sports sciences. The university has also requested the Rajasthan government's support in setting up a sports academy and arena. On November 7, Singhi signed an MoU at the Rising Rajasthan Pre-Summit, committing Rs 140 crore for the development of sports. He emphasised, "For us, sports and education go hand in hand. They are not 180 degrees apart; they are one." The session on 'Sports Industry Powering Rajasthan's Economic Growth' was moderated by Prasanth S, Partner at KPMG India.

Another panel titled 'Harnessing Science and Technology for Sports', moderated by *Sportstar's* senior sub-editor, Santadeep Dey, featured insightful discussions from prominent figures in the sports industry. Hogne Hide, co-owner of Norway Chess, highlighted the transformative power of chess, especially in India, where the game is seeing rapid growth. He expressed

excitement over the increasing youth engagement with chess, noting, "Chess has evolved into a global phenomenon, fascinating people with its rich history."

Anil Kumar, founder of Great SportsTech, reflected on the progress of sports infrastructure in India, citing a shift in the private sector's perception of sports as financially viable. "In the last 10-15 years, there has been significant investment in the sector, with both private and public sectors contributing," Kumar noted.

Martin Owens, Head Coach at Reliance Foundation Youth Sport Odisha High Performance Centre, shared a contrasting perspective on coaching in India and the UK. "The big difference between Indian athletes and those in the UK is the passion," Owens observed. "In India, sports are often seen as a route to a job, whereas in the UK, coaching is volunteer-based and driven by a love for the sport."

(L-R) Martin Owens, Head Coach of the Reliance Foundation Youth Sport Odisha High Performance Centre; Nasir Ali, MD & CEO of Gallant Sports; Anil Kumar, Founder & MD of Great SportsTech; and Dr. M.S. Dasgupta, Senior Professor in the Department of Mechanical Engineering at BITS Pilani and President of the Sports Engineering Association, addressed the gathering. R. V. MOORTHY

